

Gordon 1620

Controversiarum Epitome — the reception principle and the sole acknowledged successor (*Excerpta*)

by James Gordon Huntly, S.J. (1541–1620), Scot; *Controversiarum Epitome*, Cologne 1620

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- *Latin transcribed complete (no elisions) from the page images of the Cologne 1620 edition (MDZ bsb10773915), Controversia II (De Ecclesia): the De Oecumenicis Conciliis chapter §§IX–XVI (printed pp. 259–260) and the De Summo Pontifice sections §§XII–XIII, XVI (pp. 233–234) with the objections §§IX, XV (pp. 245, 247). Long-s normalized, tildes/-que expanded silently, original spelling retained; marginal citations bracketed. A numbering correction against earlier research notes: the supreme-judgment clause belongs to §XII (the Quintum), not §XIII — verified by catchword.*
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Note on this selection: Bellarmine’s acceptance-doctrine as it reached the classroom — a one-volume epitome of the Controversies by the Scottish Jesuit James Gordon of Huntly, printed the year of his death. Three load-bearing moments. (1) The reception principle, stated as a rule against private judgment: to the Protestant claim that the later councils were illegitimate for want of due form, “it is not for any private man to judge of this matter, but for the whole Church: and since she has received all these councils as legitimate for so many years, we must not now call them into doubt” — the same principle Cyprian (0251), Bernard (1132), and Passerinus (1670) apply to the papal title, here guarding the conciliar canon. (2) The providence argument in epitome form: the adversaries themselves concede no better remedy against heresies exists; “either this will be the certain remedy, or there will plainly be none — which is to deny divine Providence and God’s love toward his Church.” (3) On the papal side, the argument from sole acknowledgment: “no other successor of Blessed Peter than the Roman Pontiff has ever hitherto been acknowledged in the Church of Christ” — universal recognition as the public warrant of the succession, with Leo’s dictum that Peter’s “dignity does not fail even in an unworthy heir.” The two objection-answers complete the armory: Peter’s fault

at Antioch was “of conduct, not of preaching” (Tertullian), and the wicked-popes argument is “the Donatists’ argument,” refuted by Augustine — and by Calvin himself against the Anabaptists (“for Calvin well knew that among his own Ministers not a few were wicked”). Classification: School 1 (note unassigned); the entry also documents the conditions-taxonomy (§§IX–XI: illegitimate assembly or procedure, and the necessity of papal approbation — Trent seeking Pius IV’s confirmation, the same datum Erbermann’s acceptance-syllogism uses).

A. De Oecumenicis Conciliis (Controversia II, cap. XXVI; printed pp. 259–260)

§ IX — Tertium: the illegitimacy taxonomy. The third is: We acknowledge that those Councils can err which either are not legitimately assembled, or do not legitimately proceed. For such are not truly gathered in the name of Christ; of which sort were the Ariminum council of the Arians, the second Ephesine of the Eutychians, the seventh of Constantinople of the Iconoclasts: which our adversaries therefore object against us in vain.

§ X — Quartum: papal approbation required. The fourth is: Even if a Council be legitimately assembled and seem to proceed rightly, nevertheless its definitions will not be altogether certain, according to the opinion of many Catholics, unless there be added to them the approbation of the Supreme Roman Pontiff, if he himself is not present at the Council. [marg.: See Bellarmine, bk. 2 De Ecclesia militante, ch. 11.]

§ XI — Ratio: the imperfect body without its visible Head. The reason is: because before a Council is approved by the Supreme Pontiff, it is still an imperfect body of Christ, without its visible Head; and such a body can totter and fall. And hence it is that the Council of Trent sought the confirmation of Pius IV, who afterwards also solemnly approved it. Which other ancient Councils likewise sought — even those which the adversaries receive, for example the first of Nicaea, Chalcedon, the sixth synod; to say nothing of other later Councils. [marg.: Council of Trent, last session, at the end; Nicaea I (Baronius, vol. 3, an. 325, n. 171); Chalcedon, act 3, at the end, in the letter to St. Leo the Pope; the sixth synod in the letter to Agatho.]

§ XII — Quintum: the approved synod cannot err (the supreme-judgment ratio). The fifth is: We assert that an Ecumenical Synod approved by the Roman Pontiff cannot err in faith. The reason is: because there must be some supreme judgment in the Church of God, to which all are bound to submit themselves and to give undoubting faith in controverted matters, as was proved above; and there can be no supreme judgment other than this one. [marg.: Above, ch. 17 of this Controversy.]

§ XIII — the historical argument. Further, we see that from the beginning of the Church down to the present, all heresies and controversies about the dogmas of the faith have been removed through general Councils. Wherefore those who deny this open the way to all the old heresies. And since the adversaries learned this by experience with the Antitrinitarians, the Anabaptists, the Ubiquitarians, and other such, they were compelled to receive those six more ancient Councils, as has been said: but the authority of all legitimate general Councils is equal and the same.

§ XIV — the providence argument. Finally, the adversaries themselves acknowledge that there is no better or more certain remedy for removing heresies. Either, then, this will be the certain remedy, or there will plainly be none — which is to deny divine Providence and God’s love toward his Church. [marg.: Calvin, bk. 4 Inst., ch. 9, sect. 13.]

§ XV — the reception principle. Moreover, as to the adversaries' claim that the later Councils are not legitimate because they did not observe the due mode and form: this is plainly false. In the first place, because it is not for any private man to judge of this matter, but for the whole Church: and since she has received all these councils as legitimate for so many years, we must not now call them into doubt.

§ XVI — the form of synods (continuation). Further, since the adversaries receive the first six councils, the legitimate form of Synods must be sought from these; and it is plainly the same as that which has been observed in the later ones, as Baronius evidently shows for each of those first six Synods through the several ages. [Continues into a discussion of Calvin.]

B. De Summo Pontifice Romano (Controversia II; printed pp. 233–234, 245, 247)

§ XII — the keys remain, “as all acknowledge”. Further, those Keys remain always in the Church, as all acknowledge; therefore so does he to whom the keys were given. Likewise the power of binding and loosing always remains in the Church. For that power was not given, nor were those keys given, for the sake of Blessed Peter alone, but for the sake of the Church, which remains always. The Church therefore always retains both the Keys and the power of binding and loosing, in Peter and his successors.

§ XIII — the sole acknowledged successor; dignity undiminished in an unworthy heir. And this is what St. Leo says when he writes that Blessed Peter governs the Church even to the present day (namely through his successors), and that so truly that his dignity does not fail even in an unworthy heir. Moreover, no other successor of Blessed Peter than the Roman Pontiff has ever hitherto been acknowledged in the Church of Christ: therefore the Roman Pontiff is Blessed Peter's successor and the supreme Bishop of the Church; and the Roman Church is not only the true Church of Christ, but also set by Christ himself over all the others. [marg.: St. Leo, sermon 2 on the anniversary of his elevation to the Pontificate.]

§ XVI — the pastoral office perpetual. Finally, it is evident that this promise of Christ does not regard the person of Blessed Peter alone, but also his successors, who were to remain perpetually in the Church. For that the office of Pastor is ordinary, and remains perpetually in the Church, both the Apostle openly testifies, and our adversaries acknowledge. [marg.: Eph. 4:11; Calvin and Beza there; the Confession of La Rochelle, art. 25.]

§ IX — Peter rebuked: conduct, not preaching. Third argument. Even after that power was given (John 21), Peter was rebuked by St. Paul (Gal. 2). I reply: The Marcionites of old objected this very thing to the Catholics, as Tertullian testifies; to whom Tertullian replies elsewhere in these words: 'It was,' he says, 'a fault of conduct, not of preaching.' And Tertullian answers rightly: for St. Peter could perhaps have sinned then, but he could not err in faith, because he well knew that the Mosaic law was not necessary to the Gentiles for salvation, nor did he ever teach that it was necessary: nay, when controversy arose on this matter, he himself openly taught that it did not bind the Gentiles, as may be seen in the Acts of the Apostles. Wherefore if St. Peter sinned in anything, it was a sin of conduct, not of doctrine or preaching — which alone is what we are disputing about here. [marg.: Tertullian, bk. 5 against Marcion, ch. 3; Tertullian, De praescriptione adv. haer., at the end; Acts 15:10-11.]

§ XV — wicked popes: the Donatist fallacy. Sixth argument. Many of the Roman pontiffs were impious and given to various sins, as all writers, even Catholic ones, testify: therefore, just as they erred gravely in morals, so they could also err in doctrine. I reply: This very argument was of old the Donatists' argument against the Catholics, to which St. Augustine often replied. For the case of conduct and of doctrine is not the same: because an error in conduct harms only the one erring, but an error in doctrine harms others too — nay, the whole Church. Hence that admonition of Christ: 'All things whatsoever they shall say to you, observe and do: but according to their works do ye not.' Nay, Calvin himself refutes this argument of the adversaries at length, as an invention of the Anabaptists: for Calvin well knew that among his own Ministers not a few were wicked and impious. Wherefore it is a wonder that his followers so often repeat this argument. [marg.: St. Augustine, vol. 2, ep. 165 to Generosus, and vol. 7 against the letters of Petilian the Donatist, bk. 2, chs. 5, 6, 51; Matt. 23:2; Calvin, bk. 4 Inst., ch. 1, sect. 13 ff.]